

Transcend's T.Sonic 840 is an impressive offering—all the features and decent performance at an honest to goodness price of Rs 3,750, but one look at the Apacer Steno AU351 will shock you—85 per cent of the 840's performance at just 46 per cent of the price. That's value for money! Supercomp's Semp3-S7A was another such player—very decent music quality at a price of just Rs 1,500, and it even manages a tiny screen—excellent value for someone looking at something entry-level. *Digit's Best Buy* is an award few like to share, but we've seen enough to award it jointly to the Supercomp Semp3-S7A and the Apacer Steno AU351.

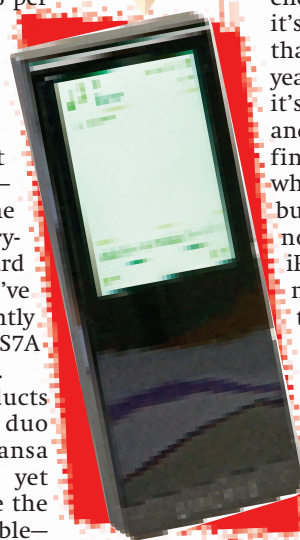
Other noteworthy products in this category are the duo from Sony and the Sansui Express. Surprise picks, yet equally good products, were the duo from the Zebronic stable—superb price for the sound quality—Rs 1,650 for the Gamma, and Rs 1,750 for the Beta. YES' YMP 30 was another excellent performer as far as music goes, and we have no qualms about recommending this to someone who's a little more discerning with sound quality.

Aigo's MP3 watch catches your fancy, but doesn't offer either the performance or the usability to please. If you're looking for a watch, chances are you'll look elsewhere. Do the same in case you want a good PMP.

FLASH-BASED PMPS

Between Rs 5,001 And
Rs 10,000

Anyone spending more than Rs 5,000 on a PMP had better know what he's buying, and that's what we're here to ensure. In general, these players have more storage space, a better list of features and even better audio and video performance. And not for nothing, because they vie for attention amidst sub-Rs 10,000 multimedia cell phones, which have their own added benefits. Features such as FM radio and better screens are taken for granted. What you need to look at is the quality of audio and video, as most of these PMPs will support movie playback—unless they're specifically targeted at *music only* user groups. Also look at photo viewing options—a neat



Samsung T10
Slim is good...

little plus point that much cheaper players—like the Transcend T.Sonic 840 in the previous category support.

Features

SanDisk's Sansa E280 has experienced a sharp decline in pricing—it's an 8 GB PMP, priced lower than its 4 GB sibling was last year! The E280 is built like a tank; it's also very traditional-looking, and has a nice solid metal back finished in matte. The scroll wheel dishes out some feedback, but it's a scroll-type wheel and not touch-sensitive like the iPod's. Speaking of which, the new Nano 3G (third generation) is gorgeous! It's nearly half the length of the previous Nano, and a little wider with a slightly larger and brighter screen. The smudge-happy yet utterly sexy chromed rear makes a comeback, and the new Nano is compact enough to sit in the tightest pockets without fuss. It's got video playback now, and Apple claims to have upped the battery life as well. Their click-wheel is as good as we remember, and with the controls designed into it, there are no protrusions of any sort on any part of the body.

Samsung's T10 is even slimmer than the Nano, and lighter,

with a fibre body instead of metal. Its sibling, the YP-S5 is very similar to the S3 from last year, with a sideways sliding body that opens to reveal the inbuilt speaker and disable the headphone jack. Both these players feature illuminated touch controls—great flaunt value, but perfectly usable. One irritation was the volume level on the headphone out getting reset to 50 per cent each time you switch from the loudspeaker to the headphones. Very unassuming and un-glamorous the Philips GoGear might be, but it's a well-built, satin black player that's replete with features. The only let down is the screen—not as bright or as clear as we'd hoped. Not unreadable, but for a video PMP, we expected better.

YES' YMP 45 is a neat PMP, made attractive by a strip of red plastic that runs around the screen and adds a touch of pizzazz to a rather ordinary black body. Mitashi's MWI-4GA has a chrome-finished posterior, but it seems to be plastic and not metal. Although the player is attractive, build quality is mediocre and the tackiness of the buttons is unacceptable. Creative's Zen is a plain looker with a black glossy front and matte-finished plastic rear

Cowon D2: A Different Beast

When we think wild, performance uncontrolled, we think Touch. When we think features, power, usability we think D2. The Cowon D2 was last year's winner, and the reason for making it two in a row is as complicated as it is simple. Why improve on perfection, or as close to it as is possible in this imperfect world?

The Cowon D2 is a very unassuming player—as small as a Nano, but twice as thick—and with very unappealing lines that make you go “Yuck!” at first. By then, you quickly realise that first impressions aren’t necessarily the last, and it’s more a device that you can live with daily rather than admire from a distance, much like the neighbourhood belle when compared to a supermodel.

You want features? How does FLAC support, inbuilt FM radio, expandable memory, a touchscreen, text reading and notepad support sound to you? This device is an amazing music player as well, and although the screen is on the small side, it offers a fantastic movie experience as well. It's very powerful, and offers more features



and performance
per cubic inch than any
vice we can think of.

The D2 is all about functionality and features, and you will find lots of settings to play with while playing music and even movies. In fact, we were surprised at the equaliser options, where cut-offs can be set for each frequency range—for example, you can set the first equaliser from 40 Hz to 80 Hz or to 110 Hz. Our only possible issue with the D2 is it's a little thick for its small dimensions, and may not gain popularity as an in-pocket jogging companion as the iPod Nano 3G. We're sorry not to find anything else to nitpick, but it's the way of a class A device to deliver all the goods with nary a hint of bad in sight.

Samsung YP-S5: The Power Of A Touch

Samsung's been known to make excellent PMPs—our only issue has been their atrocious pricing, thanks to which hardly anyone is seen totting a Samsung player. Someone in Samsung's top brass must have heard our not so silent plea, and here goes—the YP-S5 has more features than the YP-K3 we tested last year, and costs just a fraction of its predecessors' price of Rs 18,000, at just Rs 6,600. An amazing deal, this, considering the S5 is a potent all-round PMP. It has an amazing LCD screen—that at first glance appears to be an OLED screen—and soft touch controls that are backlit in very pleasing colours such as cool blue and light yellow. We can guarantee looks from just about anyone if you just whip out this player, because chances are people will figure it for being at least thrice as expensive.



It features Bluetooth, a rare but useful feature in case you want to transfer music from it to your cell phone or even PC, but the S5 itself requires to be synced with a PC to transfer music. While on the topic, sound quality is very good, and the S5 approaches the quality of costlier players easily. Its got a very clean and crisp sound to the vocals, and both male and female vocals seem to come alive. While it doesn't go as low as the Cowon D2 or the iPod Nano and Touch, the bass definitely can't be termed as deficient in any way. It also provides sufficient volume to drive most headphones properly, and we didn't notice any issues on our two reference models.

If you're looking at something extremely usable at a great price, but you want something that stands out and feels far more expensive than its price, the S5 is a tailor-made fit. It represents the best value amongst the sub-Rs 10,000 PMPs and is one of those rare products that actually offers more satisfaction for the compensation it demands.

that's been moulded to look like ripples in water after a splash. Note that the Zen has a large-ish screen, and is targeted at video aficionados. Cowon's iAudio 7 is another neat looker—very compact and very well built. The screen isn't as good as some of the other players, particularly the Samsung models, the iPod Nano, the Sansa E280 and the iRiver X20.

The Sansa E280 has all the features you need—music, photo and video support, FM radio, text support and even expandability (should 8 GB not suffice). The iPod Nano has most of these features (excluding FM radio and expandability), and the addition of nifty add-ons like a stopwatch, alarm, calendar and contacts make the Nano a superbly converged device. Unlike older Nanos, this one can also be used as a pen drive. Both Samsung PMPs also have Bluetooth support, which can be used to transfer music to (but not from) other devices—that's taking anti-piracy nuttiness to the limit, in our opinion.

Sony's NWZ-615F also impressed with its feature list, the only thing missing is expandability (and Bluetooth, which was exclusive to the Samsung PMPs).



Apple iPod Nano 3G 4 GB
Pocket audiophile



Performance

Our first major fight for top spot sees the excellent Samsung YP-S5 and the T10 slug it out with the Apple iPod Nano 3G, the SanDisk Sansa E280 and the Cowon iAudio 7, with the iRiver X20 neck and neck with everyone. Both Samsungs aren't flawless, however—closer tests reveal what seemed like a slight roll-off for lower frequency sounds in the first couple of octaves. The highs sound excellent, however, and female vocals are delivered outstandingly. If we were to choose the two best-sounding PMPs from this excellent lot, the laurels would rest with the iPod Nano and the iRiver X20. From the lower to the upper bass ranges, low frequencies are defined and tight, yet the thump is very apparent—something that is as important for bass-heads as it is for audiophiles. The mid-range is well-defined, smooth and full bodied, and guitar detailing will